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Microsoft-free desktop solution, courtesy IBM

IBM has announced the availability of a Linux desktop solution designed to drive savings compared to Microsoft's desktop software. The combined solution includes virtual desktop, Ubuntu, and IBM Open Collaboration Client Solution software. This Microsoft-free solution runs open standards-based e-mail, word processing, spreadsheets, unified communication, social networking and other software to any laptop, browser or mobile device from a virtual desktop login on a Linux-based server configuration.

A virtual desktop, which looks like a traditional desktop, is not limited to a single physical computer, according to the company. Instead, many virtual Linux desktops are hosted on a server. The combined solution includes: virtual desktop provided by Virtual Bridges called Virtual Enterprise Remote Desktop Environment (VERDE); Ubuntu; and IBM Open Collaboration Client Solution software (OCCS) based on IBM Lotus Symphony, IBM Lotus Notes and Lotus applications. IBM Lotus Symphony is built on the Open Document Format (ODF).

This solution is now a key component of IBM's financial services front office transformation offering, as well as part of the IBM public sector industry solution framework.

Compared to Microsoft-based desktops, this virtual desktop solution will enable cost avoidance of \$500 to \$800 per user on software licences for Microsoft Office, Windows and all related products. It will also translate to cost avoidance of around \$258 per user since there is no need to upgrade hardware to support Windows Vista and Office 2007, a cost avoidance of \$40 to \$145 per user from reduced power to run the configuration, and \$20 to \$73 per user from reduced air conditioning requirements from lower powered desktop devices, annually. Other potential benefits are a 90 per cent savings of desk-side PC support, 75 per cent on security/user administration, 50 per cent of help-desk services such as password resets, and 50 per cent for software installations, which are replaced by software publishing.

Sun's new initiative for emerging markets

To expand its customer base across its emerging markets (EM), Sun Microsystems has rolled out a regional tele-coverage model that will help reach high-growth SMBs, start-ups and Web 2.0 companies in emerging economies. The tele-coverage model will go live across the EM region and will be implemented by local companies that Sun has partnered with in these markets. The EM region consists of 139 countries spanning Latin America, South and Eastern Europe, India and Greater China.

On this initiative, Peter Ryan, executive vice president, global sales and services, Sun Microsystems, said, "Today's roll out of the tele-coverage model is Sun's first major initiative in the EM region. This new business tool supports our sales efforts and increases the average number of leads generated, lead-to-order conversion and new customer acquisition. This model also demonstrates the investment we are making in these geographies through our local partners."

The tele-coverage model, first implemented in India, has been operationally very successful here for the last six years, the company claimed. It has been instrumental in contributing to a significant part of Sun's local revenue growth.

Wind River to offer commercial Android solution

Wind River is going to offer a commercial software solution based on Android, the open source mobile software. The solution will comprise software systems integration services and a compatible commercially supported Android software platform for handset manufacturers and mobile operators planning to develop Android-based devices and services.

Wind River's commercial software platform for Android is expected to include the latest open source Android software and Wind River's commercial-grade Linux. This also includes Android-specific Linux patches, and pre-integrated third-party technologies to help commercialise Android. Additionally, the platform is expected to be optimised on leading mobile semiconductor hardware from which manufacturers can quickly build market-differentiated products. Wind River's commercially supported Android software platform is expected to be available in the first half of 2009.

Huawei to launch Android phone in 2009

Huawei Technologies has announced its entry into the Open Handset Alliance and its plan to launch smartphones based on the Android

platform in 2009. Supporting the Android platform, members of the Alliance promote an integrated mobile software stack that incorporates the operating system, middleware, user-friendly interfaces and applications. Huawei has established strategic partnerships with most of the Alliance's members, including China Mobile, Telefónica and T-Mobile.

